

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 6.1

FORMS AND STRUCTURES IN COMMON ORTHODOX CHANT. THE CONCEPT OF EIGHT TONES.



FORMS AND STRUCTURES IN COMMON ORTHODOX CHANT

In Unit 5.2 (Slide 12) we mentioned that one of the strategies a church singer can employ in sight-singing an unfamiliar melody is **knowledge of the patterns of Eight Tones** (also known by the Greek term “Octoechos”).

Patterns of pitches and rhythms (we can call them **motives**) are the basic building blocks that make up larger units called **phrases**, which, in turn, constitute what are called **musical forms**. The general study of forms in music is an entire topic in and of itself. In this course, it is important to consider the forms found in the various categories of chant melodies, insofar as they help us become better sight-readers.

An advance knowledge of forms—how a given church hymn is structured—serves as an important tool: knowing how a musical phrase is knit together, and how one phrase follows another, allows us to anticipate how we are supposed to sing them.

“MACRO-” AND “MICRO-” STRUCTURES IN CHANT

In Unit 3.2 (Slide 12) we mentioned the fact that within the system of Eight Tones as sung in Churches of Eastern Slavic origins, different melodic patterns are used for specific categories of Orthodox hymns. These categories are:

1. **Troparia** and **Kontakia**
2. **Stichera**
3. **Heirmoi of Kanons** (aka Canons)
4. **Prokeimena** and **Alleluias**.

The form or structure of each Tone consists of between one and five different melodic phrases or patterns, arranged in a specific order or sequence. This overall structure is referred to as the **macrostructure** (or macro-form), and allows the informed singer to anticipate what musical phrase comes next.

We have seen examples of the macrostructures (marked by numbers in large circles) of several different melodies from the Eight Tones in previous units (see Unit 2.2, Slides 6, 7, & 8, and Unit 3.2, Slides 11, 13, 14, 15, 16, and 17).

“MACRO-” AND “MICRO-” STRUCTURES IN CHANT (CONT'D)

Looking more closely at the structure of each phrase, we notice that chant phrases often begin with several distinct melodic notes that can be organized into a metric pattern—termed the **beginning** (*incipit* in Latin)—for example, two or three half-note beats; this is followed by a passage of **recitation** (a.k.a. the **reciting tone**); this in turn is followed by the **ending** (a.k.a. the **cadence**), which, just like the beginning, often consists of several distinct melodic notes that can be organized into two or three half-note beats.

In some Tones certain phrases may not have a distinct “beginning” but start right away with the reciting tone.

The length of the reciting-tone section varies greatly, depending on the length of the text phrase. This flexibility of musical structure allows texts of varying length, written in what is essentially prose or free verse (as opposed to metered poetry), to be sung to melodies that are **identifiably similar**, “in” or “belonging to” a certain Tone.

“MACRO-” AND “MICRO-” STRUCTURES IN CHANT (CONT'D)

The “beginning,” “reciting tone,” and “ending” constitute the **microstructure** (or micro-form) of chant phrases, and are illustrated in the following example of the Resurrectional Troparion in Tone 1 (Russian “Common” Chant).

In the example below, the circled numerals indicate the macrostructure of melodic phrases, while the brackets over the musical notes show the beginning (if any), reciting tone, and ending within each phrase.

The image displays three staves of musical notation for the Resurrectional Troparion in Tone 1 (Russian “Common” Chant). Each staff is labeled with a circled numeral indicating the macrostructure of the melodic phrase. Brackets above the notes indicate the microstructure, specifically the beginning, reciting tone, and ending of each phrase.

Staff 1 (Macrostructure 1): The first staff is labeled “Melody” and “1”. It shows the beginning, reciting tone, and ending of the first phrase. The text below the staff is “When the stone__ had been sealed by the Jews,”.

Staff 2 (Macrostructure 2a): The second staff is labeled “2a”. It shows the reciting tone and ending of the second phrase. The text below the staff is “while the soldiers were guarding Your most pure bod - y,”.

Staff 3 (Macrostructure 2b): The third staff is labeled “2b”. It shows the reciting tone and ending of the third phrase. The text below the staff is “You rose on the third day, O Savior, granting life to the”.

The image displays the musical notation for Troparion Tone 1 in G Major. The melody is written on a single staff with a treble clef and a key signature of one sharp (F#). The text is written below the staff, and the melody is divided into sections by brackets and labels.

The first line of music starts with a bracket labeled "1" and "Beginning". The melody consists of a half note G4, a quarter note A4, a quarter note B4, and a quarter note C5. This is followed by a bracket labeled "Reciting tone" covering the notes D5, E5, F#5, and G5. The line ends with a bracket labeled "Ending" covering the notes A5, B5, and C6.

The second line of music starts with a bracket labeled "2a" and "Reciting tone". The melody consists of a half note D5, a quarter note E5, a quarter note F#5, and a quarter note G5. This is followed by a bracket labeled "Ending" covering the notes A5, B5, and C6.

The third line of music starts with a bracket labeled "2a" and "Ending". The melody consists of a half note D5, a quarter note E5, a quarter note F#5, and a quarter note G5. This is followed by a bracket labeled "2b" and "Reciting tone" covering the notes A5, B5, and C6.

The fourth line of music starts with a bracket labeled "Ending". The melody consists of a half note D5, a quarter note E5, a quarter note F#5, and a quarter note G5. The line ends with a double bar line.

The text of the Troparion is: "world. The powers of heaven therefore cried to You, O Giver of Life: 'Glory to Your Resurrection, O Christ! Glory to Your Kingdom! Glory to Your dispensation, O Lover of man-kind!'"

Using your recently gained knowledge of notes and intervals in the key of G Major, you certainly have the ability to sight-sing this Troparion. But notice how being familiar with the macrostructure and the microstructures of Common Chant Troparion Tone 1 helps you anticipate how this melody sounds. Sing and record it.

Please proceed to **FORM ANALYSIS EXERCISES 6.1**

Бѣстѣнный Тропарь Воскресный. Гласъ 4. Па. в.

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рѣ ѡ ѡ мѣ ро ки жи знь ꙗ си гѡ ра дѣ си и